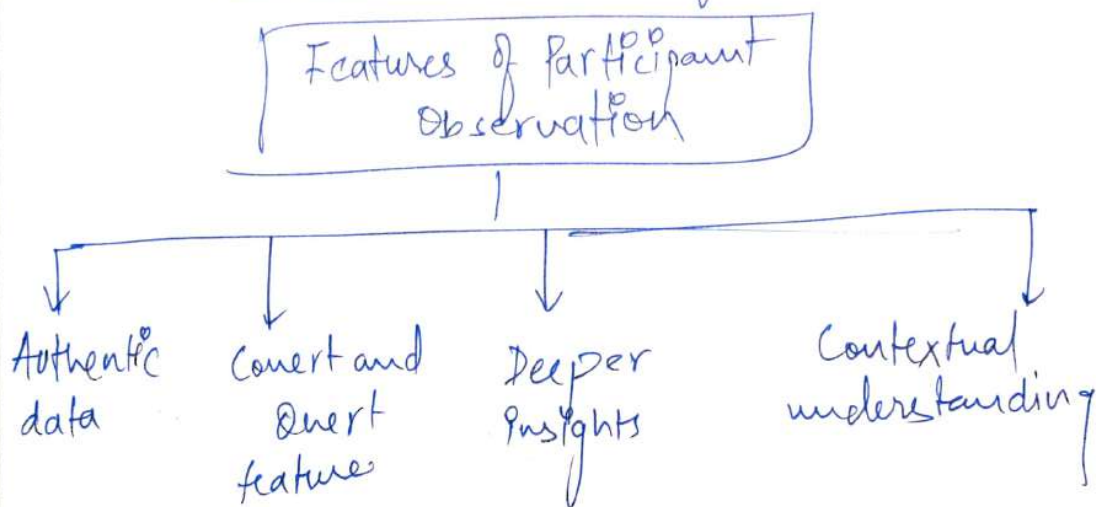


- 3.c) Evaluate the debates around the use of participant observation as a research method in anthropology. What are the ethical and methodological controversies associated with this approach? (15 marks)

Participant observation is a data collection technique in which the anthropologist become part of culture to study in holistic manner.



Debates have arisen about using participant observation in anthropology

Support for method

- ① Participant observation ensure that the data collected is contextual and present emic understanding.
- ② 'Native' understanding is highlighted.
- ③ Cultural narratives are understood.

Case study → Kenneth Good conducting 12 years observation of Xanomamo. Gave understanding of cultural practices, social structure. Later due to long study highlighted effects of globalization. Post returning, new ideas like Culture shock and Reverse culture shock highlighted.

Against using participant observation:

- ① Time consuming and narrowed field of vision of studies (eg. Ceslie White said historical data collection without forming general laws was not the right approach).
- ② Role of Local Elites → May lead to highlighting data that protects their own social position.

Ethical issues with participant observation

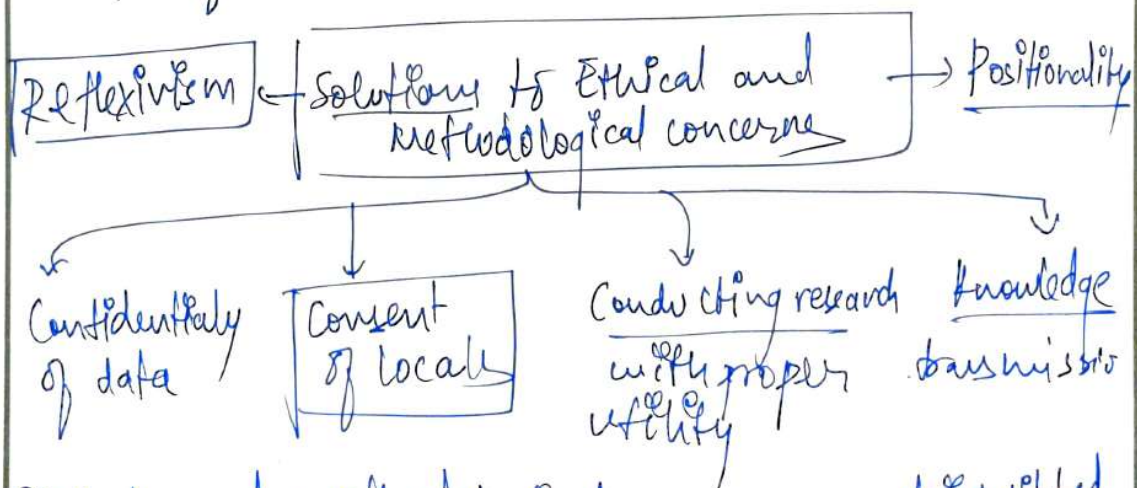
- ① Own bias and ethnocentric views.

(eg) Malinowski's Diary and 'Argonauts of Western Pacific' showing varying interpretation of Trobrianders

- ② Challenge of locals believing change may come as result of study.
- ③ Outcome of studies may be negative
(eg. Project Camelot by USA government) ⇒ Anthropological studies south American countries used for political instability.

Methodological issues associated: -

- ① Emotional attachment with locals
(eg. Kenneth Good married Yanomamo woman.
- ② Interpretation of holism → Not all fields have to be studied but their integration has to be understood.



Ethical and methodological concerns highlighted show that anthropology as a social science is undergoing constant change.